

THE CATCH

SAME RULES. LOUDER CONSEQUENCES.

OFFICIAL RULEBOOK — HOW TO PLAY

PLAYERS

1 – 6 per phone

ROUNDS

7 + The One

TIME

20 – 40 min

YOU NEED

1 phone + the deck

ALSO

Online mode

The Catch is a dating game played with a phone and a deck of trait cards. The app shows you who's on the market. The cards hold their secrets. Peek, bluff, date or ghost — then flip the cards and find out who you really went home with.

♥ DATE

👁️ GHOST

👁️ LOOK

🔍 STALK

📄 TRAIT CARDS

SECTION 01

WHAT YOU NEED & HOW TO START

IN THE BOX

64 trait cards	Numbered № 01–64. Green, yellow and red flags with their point values.
6 blank cards	3 green (+2) and 3 red (–2) to write your own.
30 stalk chips	3 per player.
2 rules cards	The short version of this book.
One phone	Open bymayawalsh.design → The Catch → ► PLAY. No app, no login.

1 Who's Playing

Add 1–6 players on the one phone — a name, an avatar and a player type each. Playing alone? 2 AI rivals join you and decide alongside you.

2 Pick a Player Type

Your type changes how every card scores for you. Locked in for the whole game.

 The Romantic — every positive +1	 The Selective — every negative –1 more
 The Chaotic One — negatives +2 (max 0)	 The Overthinker — –1 → –3, 0 → –1
 The Avoidant — +3s –1, –2s & worse –1	 The Gold Digger — +2s & up +1, –2s & worse –1

3 Write Your Own (Optional)

Write real behaviors you've seen on the blank cards, then type them into the app. Each gets a label — W1, W2... — write it on the card. The app will deal them like any other.

4 Set the Table

Keep the deck sorted by number so cards are quick to pull. Give everyone 3 stalk chips. Press START — the app builds 7 profiles, one of them a hidden **Catfish**.

SECTION 02

HOW A ROUND WORKS

1

Deal

The app shows the profile — name, archetype and an illustrated avatar — and the cards to deal. Put the first 2 face-up (the visible traits, always their mildest) and the other 4 face-down.

2

Look & Stalk

Before you decide, dig.  LOOK in the app swaps the avatar for their real black-and-white photo.  STALK at the table: spend a chip, secretly peek at one face-down card, put it back. Tell no one.

3

Decide

Each player takes the phone in turn — "Pass the device" — and taps ♥ DATE or ○ GHOST in private.

4

Flip & Score

Flip the face-down cards one by one as the app reveals them. The app scores everyone for their type and shows the leaderboard. Put the cards back in the deck — the app may deal them again later.

♥ DATE

APP

Score every card, adjusted by your type. A negative total costs a heart. Always allowed.

○ GHOST

APP · 3 EACH

Pass for ±0 — or +1 if it was the Catfish. When your 3 ghosts are gone, you have to date.

LOOK

APP · 3 EACH

See their real photo — once per profile. You always see the avatar first; the photo only after a LOOK.

STALK

TABLE · 3 CHIPS

Spend a chip to secretly peek at one face-down card. Stack them on one profile if you like.

SECTION 03

SCORING & TRAIT CARDS

CARD	VALUE	COLOR
Green Flag — good vibes	+1 to +3	● Mint
Yellow Flag — mildly concerning	0 to -1	● Gold
Red Flag — actual problems	-2 to -3	● Neon Red

Write-your-own cards score +2 (green) or -2 (red).

5 Your Type Changes the Math

The printed value is the base. The app runs every card through your type before adding up — a Romantic's +2 is a +3; an Overthinker's -1 is a -3.

6 Hearts

Everyone starts with 3. You lose one each time you DATE and your total is negative — and dating the Catfish always costs one. At 0 hearts you're **Heartbroken**: every positive score is halved (the ½ in your bar) and you can't face The One.

BONUSES & PENALTIES

Date scores -5 or worse Red Flag — lose 2 more points

Date scores 7+ (solo) +2 bonus

Date scores 7+ (table) Chemistry — +2, but only if you were the only one who dated them

Heartbroken Positive scores halved

🧛 THE CATFISH

One profile per game (rounds 2–5) is a Catfish. It looks like everyone else — a normal name, archetype and avatar — but its 2 face-up cards are green flags and all 4 face-down cards are -3. DATE it: -4 on top, plus a heart. GHOST it: +1 and Catfish Dodger.

SECTION 04

THE ONE & ENDGAME

💖 WHAT IS "THE ONE"?

After 7 rounds, everyone with 10+ points *and* at least 1 heart meets a final legendary profile — **The One**. There are no cards for this one: it plays out entirely in the app. One trait is visible (+2); four are hidden: 0, +2, -1 and a big +5 — +8 before your type gets its say.

7

Face The One

Each qualified player chooses 🎲 **TAKE A CHANCE** or 🚶 **WALK AWAY** in private. If your type-adjusted total is 7 or more, you found The One: +10. Under 7: -10 and a heart. Walking away changes nothing. Nobody qualified? Straight to results.

8

Results

Highest total wins. Everyone gets a title — The Catch, The Romantic, The Ghost, The Fun Ghoster, The Risk Taker or The Selective One — and their achievements. Playing solo, you're ranked against your 2 rivals.

THE ONE

To qualify	10+ points and at least 1 heart after round 7
Base total	+8, adjusted by your type
Take a chance	7+ → +10 · under 7 → -10 and a heart
Walk away	No change

TIES AT THE TABLE

1st tiebreak	Most hearts left
Still tied?	⚡ Speed Dating — one last profile in the app. Tied players choose DATE or GHOST in private.
Who wins	If the profile scores positive, the only one who dated. If not, the only one who ghosted.

SECTION 05

ACHIEVEMENTS

Achievements track the story of your run — not just your score. They pop up when earned and appear on the final results.

 CATFISH DODGER Ghosted the Catfish. You felt something was off.	 GOT CATFISHED Dated the Catfish. Should have trusted your gut.	 GHOST MASTER Used all three ghosts. No mess, no drama.
 CHAOS ENJOYER Went on 2+ Red Flag dates and came back for more.	 FOUND THE ONE Took the chance on The One and it paid off.	 UNMATCHED Took the chance on The One and lost.
 SMOOTH CRIMINAL Online only: used Steal.	 DOUBLE DATER Online only: chose Double Date.	 RED FLAG RADAR Locked — coming soon.
 NO SURVIVORS Locked — coming soon.	 THERAPIZED Retired with Therapy.	

QUICK REFERENCE

EACH PLAYER GETS		EACH GAME HAS	
Hearts	3	Profiles	7, each dealt 6 cards
Ghosts	3 (in the app)	Catfish	1, somewhere in rounds 2–5
Looks	3, once per profile (app)	The One	After round 7, app only
Stalk chips	3 (at the table)	Cards	Back in the deck every round

SECTION 06

PLAYING ONLINE

Not in the same room? Online mode plays The Catch on everyone's own phone — no cards needed. The traits live on screen instead.

1 Join a Room

Press ↗ PLAY ONLINE. One player taps CREATE A ROOM and shares the 4-letter code; everyone else taps JOIN A ROOM. Each player picks a name and a type. You need at least 2 players.

2 Decide Together

Everyone sees the same profile and decides at the same time, in secret, with a **30-second timer** — let it run out and you ghost. The host moves the game to the next round.

⚡ STEAL

ONLINE • 1 USE

Skip the date and take up to 3 points from the highest-scoring other player — never more than they have.

♥♥ DOUBLE DATE

ONLINE

If 2+ players pick it, the score is split evenly between them. Pick it alone and it's a normal date.

HOW ONLINE DIFFERS

Cards	None — traits reveal on screen
Look	Not available online
Scoring	Face value — no bonus, Red Flag penalty or Heartbroken
Catfish	Same: date -4, ghost +1
The One	DATE adds your type-adjusted total; negative costs a heart
Ties	No tiebreaker round

SECTION 07

STRATEGY & TIPS

**Watch who stalks**

A peek is secret, but the chip isn't. Someone stalked and then ghosted? They probably found a red flag.

**Bluff your peeks**

Found a +3? Hesitate. Found a -3? Look pleased. Your face is a card too.

**Catfish detection**

Profiles usually lead with their mildest traits — two strong green flags face-up is suspicious. Spend a LOOK: the Catfish's photo looks a lot older than their age.

**Save ghosts for the worst**

You only get 3, and when they're gone you have to date. Don't spend them on profiles that might be fine.

**Chase chemistry**

At the table, a great date only earns the +2 if you're the only one who went. Sometimes the best move is the one nobody else makes.

**Protect your hearts**

Hearts are your ticket to The One — and at 0 your good dates only count half. Down to 1? Ghost the risky ones.

**Know your type before The One**

Every type clears The One's 7-point bar — except The Overthinker, whose math lands on 5. Overthinkers: walk away.

THE GOLDEN RULE

Every profile has 6 cards. You see 2 before deciding. Everything else is a bet. The game isn't about being right — it's about making better bets than everyone else.